

HOLT APAC

China AI Capex: Assessing affordability, market perception, and value creation

As Chinese cloud service providers (CSPs) accelerate AI capex, pressure on near-term FCF and profitability has raised familiar questions around affordability and returns. We assess China AI capex through a HOLT lens on Alibaba, Tencent, and Baidu. Overall, Chinese CSPs appear financially resilient despite rising AI investments, while Alibaba and Tencent appear on track for stronger value creation. Historical evidence also suggests markets could reward growth-oriented capital allocation with higher valuations.

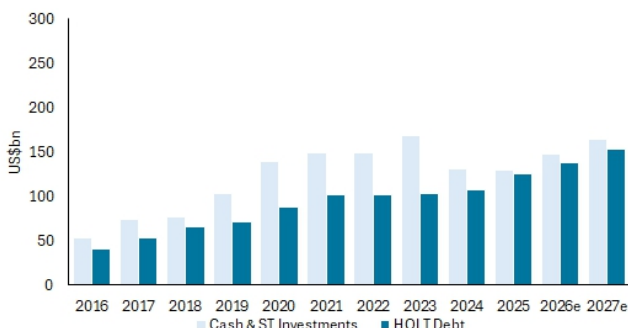
AI Capex affordability: Chinese cloud service providers (CSPs) retain funding sustainability

AI capex has become a growing investor concern as elevated spending has pushed several US hyperscalers into negative free cash flow and increased reliance on external funding. With Chinese CSPs also reporting AI-driven free cash flow pressure in the latest quarter, affordability has become an increasingly important question for investors.

Figure 1 shows that Chinese CSPs are forecast to maintain net cash positions on an aggregate level despite rising AI investments, while US hyperscalers move further into net debt. Fixed-charge coverage tells a similar story: Chinese platforms should continue generating cash flow in excess of capex and fixed obligations (Figure 3 & Figure 4), whereas US hyperscalers may become increasingly reliant on debt financing (See [HOLT Global Viewpoint](#) by Michel Lerner).

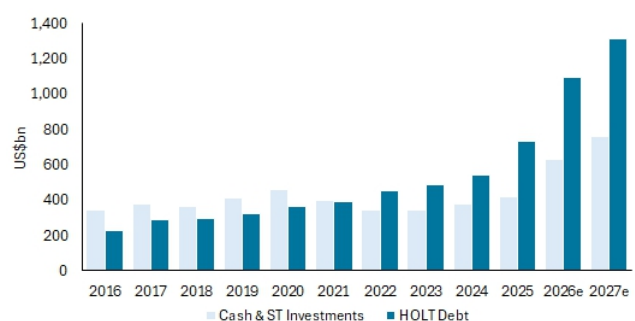
At the company level, Alibaba appears the most aggressive in AI spending, with fixed-charge coverage falling below 100% from 2025 onwards (Figure 5). By contrast, Tencent has maintained a more measured investment pace, while local media reports suggest Baidu may continue funding AI capex through existing cash balances and operating cash flow. Overall, it appears Chinese hyperscalers as a group remain financially resilient, supported by relatively low capex intensity (Figure 6) and operating discipline.

Figure 1: Chinese CSPs remain in net cash position on aggregate level despite heightened AI investments



Source: UBS HOLT. Includes Alibaba, Tencent, Baidu. 2026e represents current unreported fiscal year, 2027e represents next fiscal year.

Figure 2: US Hyperscalers remain in net debt position on aggregate level



Source: UBS HOLT. Includes Microsoft, Amazon, Alphabet, Meta, and Oracle. 2026e represents current unreported fiscal year, 2027e represents next fiscal year. For Microsoft, fy2026 financials are included in 2025 as it has a June year-end.

Equities

China
Internet Services

Shawn Lee

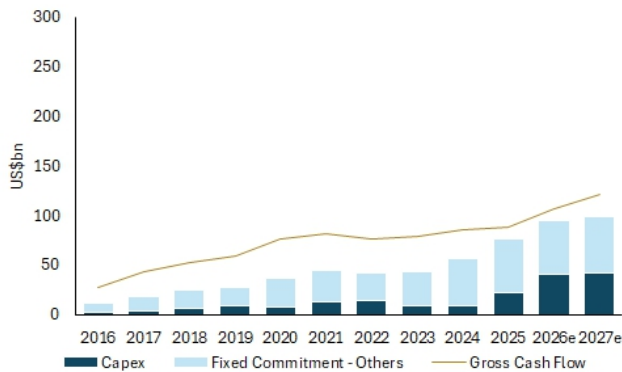
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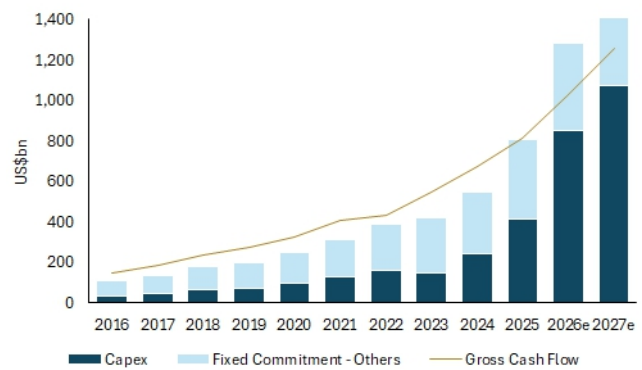
Major AI infrastructure investors in China include listed internet CSPs Alibaba, Tencent, and Baidu; private tech giants ByteDance and Huawei; as well as state-owned telecom operators. In the US, AI capital spending is concentrated among hyperscalers, particularly Microsoft, Amazon, Alphabet, Meta, and Oracle.

Figure 3: Chinese CSPs generate sufficient cash on aggregate level to fund Capex and other fixed commitments



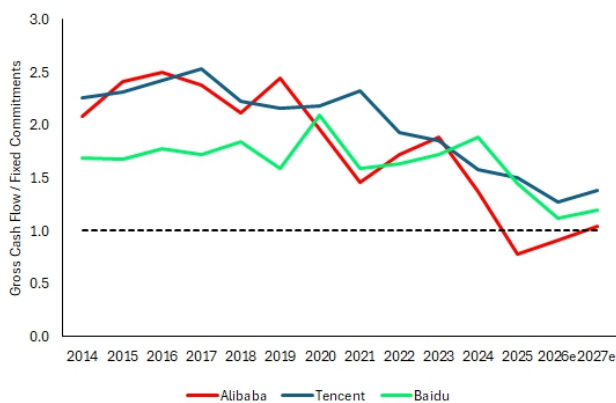
Source: UBS HOLT. Includes Alibaba, Tencent, Baidu.

Figure 4: US Hyperscalers' Gross Cash Flow no longer covers fixed capital commitments on aggregate level



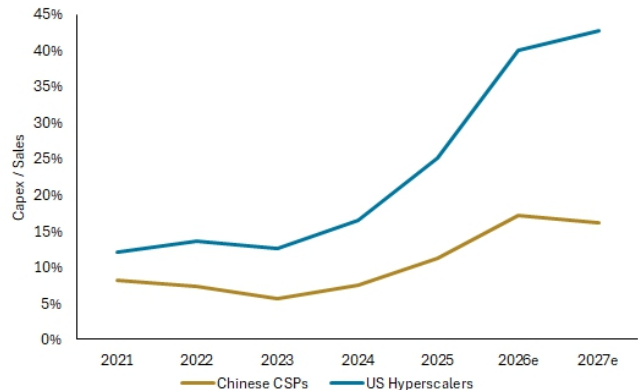
Source: UBS HOLT. Includes Microsoft, Amazon, Alphabet, Meta, and Oracle.

Figure 5: Fixed charge coverage ratio for Chinese CSPs



Source: UBS HOLT. Fixed charge coverage ratio is Gross Cash Flow / fixed capital commitments.

Figure 6: Capex intensity is lower for Chinese CSPs compared to US hyperscalers



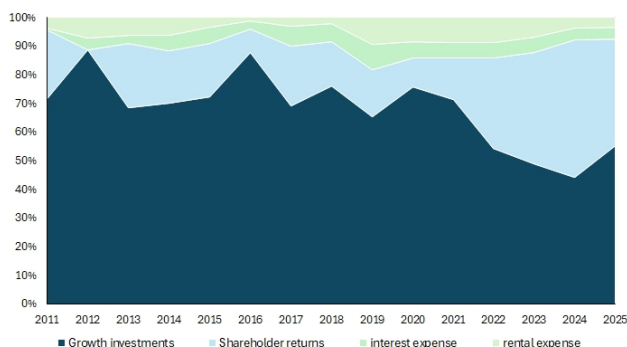
Source: UBS HOLT. Refinitive. Capex intensity is Capex/Sales.

Market perception: Is the market rewarding growth investments with higher valuation multiples?

Figure 7 shows how [Alibaba](#) and [Tencent](#) have allocated capital across industry cycles. During the rapid expansion of the 2010s, growth investment accounted for c.70%-80% of cash deployment through M&A, R&D, and capex. Following the 2020-21 industry regulatory tightening, capital allocation shifted toward shareholder returns, with dividends and buybacks exceeding 40% of total deployment. Since 2025, the balance has tilted back toward growth investment, driven primarily by AI capex.

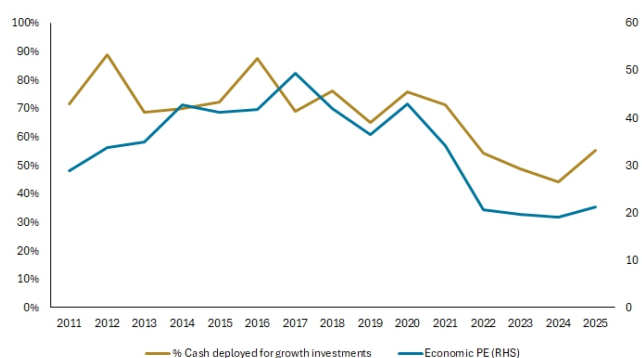
Historically, Economic P/E has been positively correlated with the share of cash deployed into growth investment (Figure 8). Investors have generally rewarded reinvestment when it supports future growth opportunities. If AI investment translates into sustainable growth and value creation, the recent shift toward investment-led capital allocation could also be viewed positively.

Figure 7: Alibaba, Tencent - Aggregate cash deployment %



Source: UBS HOLT. Growth investments include cash deployed in M&A, R&D, Capex. Shareholder returns include cash deployed in buyback and dividends.

Figure 8: Alibaba, Tencent - % cash deployed in growth investments vs Economic PE



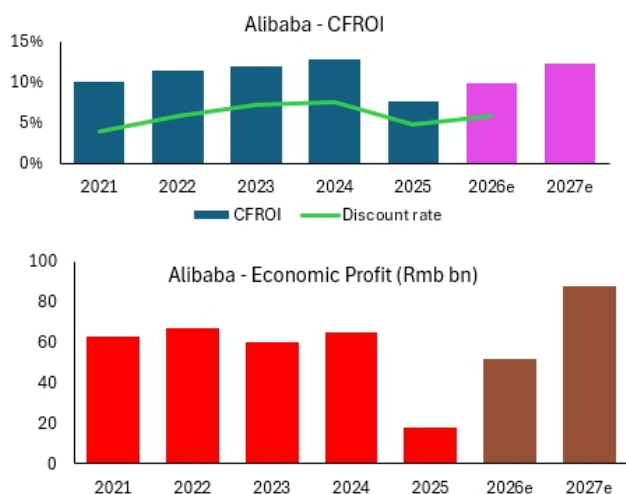
Source: UBS HOLT. Aggregate Economic PE is on weighted basis. Annual Economic PE is average of monthly Economic PE.

AI Capex ROI: Long-term value creation intact

While AI investment weighs on near-term FCF and CFROI, the HOLT framework evaluates AI capex through long-term Economic Profit rather than upfront cash costs. A temporary decline in CFROI can be offset by stronger asset growth if new investment continues to earn positive CFROI spreads, resulting in higher Economic Profit and value creation (see [The Hyperscaler Paradox](#) by HOLT US TMT specialist John Talbott). On a fundamental view, strong cloud growth, growing order backlog (for US hyperscalers), AI rampup and increasing disclosure over past quarters support the view that AI investment should be assessed on long-term value creation rather than upfront cash costs.

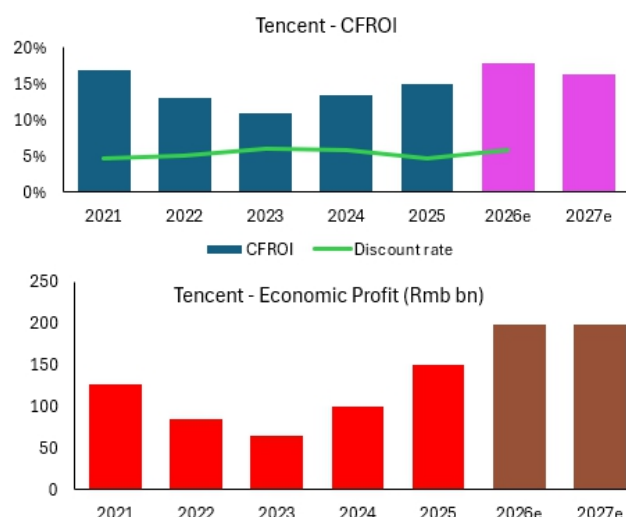
In addition to AI investments, CFROI trends for China internet platforms continue to reflect competition, cost discipline, and broader consumption (see [HOLT China Internet](#) report). As competitive intensity normalizes and operational efficiency improves, consensus forecasts point to a recovery in CFROI over the next two years. Combined with ongoing asset growth from AI investment, this could lift Alibaba's Economic Profit to a five-year high and Tencent's to a record high by 2027e.

Figure 9: Alibaba - Economic Profit forecast to reach five-year high in 2027e



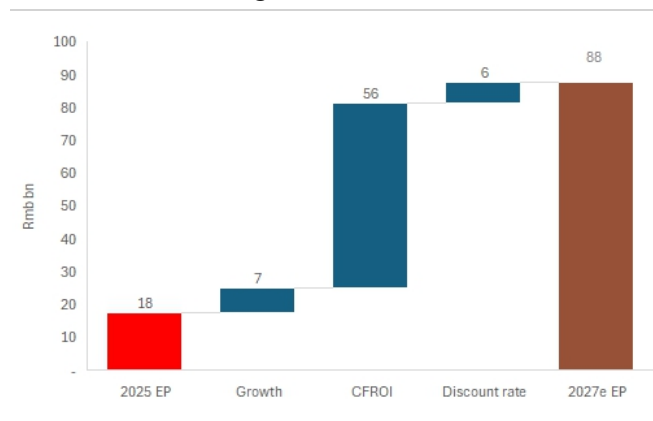
Source: UBS HOLT.

Figure 10: Tencent - Economic Profit forecast to reach record high in 2027e



Source: UBS HOLT.

Figure 11: Alibaba - Economic Profit growth is driven by both CFROI and asset growth



Source: UBS HOLT.

Figure 12: Tencent - Economic Profit growth is driven by both CFROI and asset growth



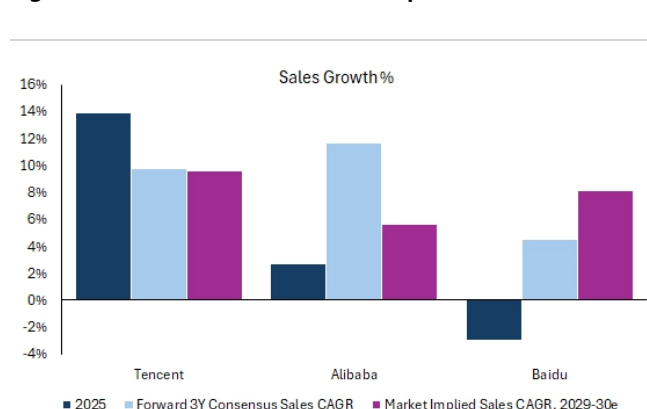
Source: UBS HOLT.

What's priced in?

Tencent is priced for CFROI to fade below both forecast and historical levels ([Figure 15](#)), suggesting cautious expectations despite resilient fundamentals and improving Economic Profit. Current share price implies long-term sales growth stabilizing at c.10% ([Figure 13](#)), alongside a steady improvement in EBITDA margins to 42% ([click here](#)). Relative to peers, the market appears to be pricing in more conservative return expectations, which may reflect limited expectations for AI monetization. This setup could create a more favorable risk-reward profile if AI monetization and cloud growth continue to gain traction, as Tencent stepped up its AI capex significantly last quarter.

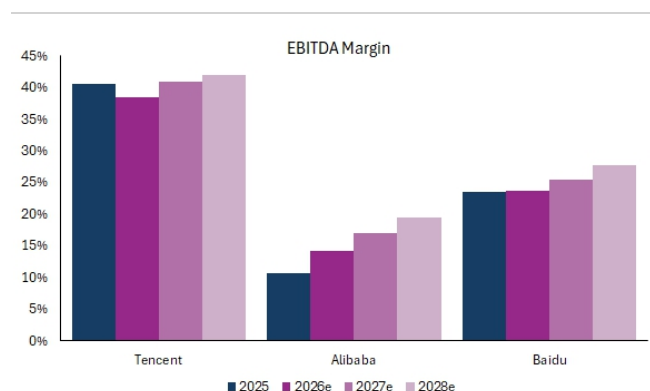
Alibaba is priced for long-term CFROI to recover from its 2025 trough and sustain around the 2027e forecast level ([Figure 17](#)). Current share price implies long-term sales growth moderating to c.6% from the near-term consensus forecast of 12%, with EBITDA margins expanding materially to 19% ([click here](#)). In addition to better AI model capability, the company's comprehensive disclosure around AI and cloud metrics, together with management commentary on AI ROIC and the roadmap, provides greater visibility into AI economics and monetization. This could support further AI-driven rerating if monetization outcomes exceed current forecast assumptions. **Baidu**, by contrast, is priced for a substantial improvement in both sales growth and EBITDA margins relative to historical and forecast levels ([click here](#)), suggesting the market already embeds meaningful AI monetization upside despite ongoing weakness in the core business.

Figure 13: Chinese CSPs - Market Implied Sales Growth



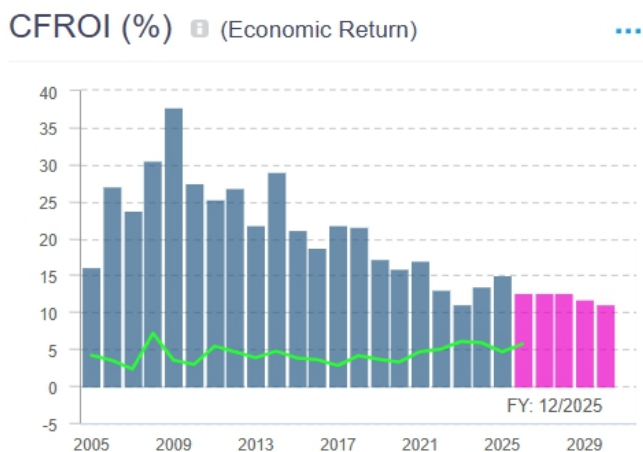
Source: UBS HOLT. Hong Kong market base rate of 7.3% is used as discount rate for Baidu. Forecast based on IBES consensus estimates.

Figure 14: Chinese CSPs - EBITDA Margin consensus forecast



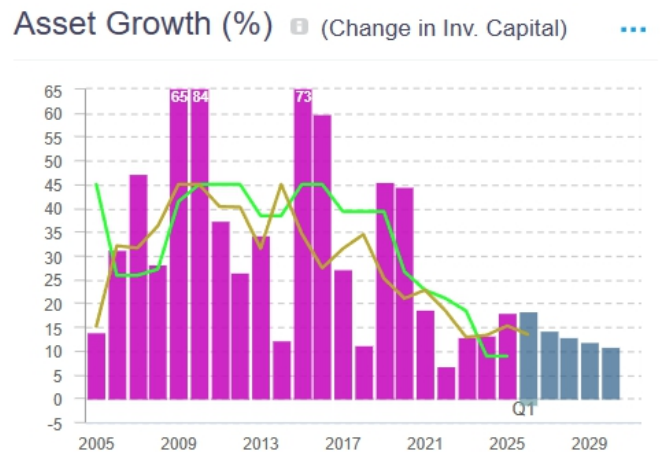
Source: UBS HOLT. Forecast based on IBES consensus estimates.

Figure 15: Tencent - Market implied CFROI



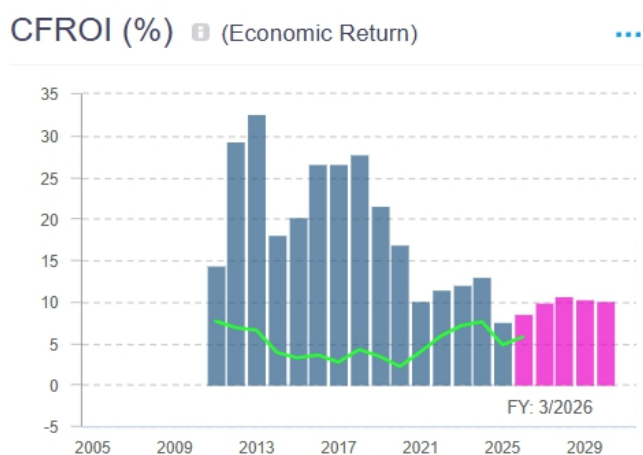
Source: UBS HOLT.

Figure 16: Tencent - Market implied Asset Growth



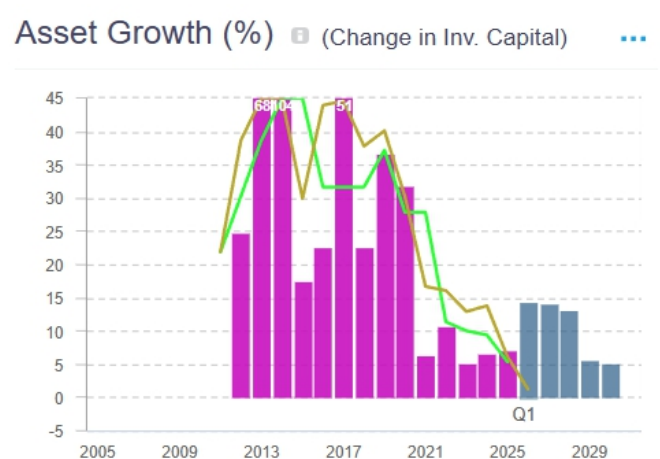
Source: UBS HOLT.

Figure 17: Alibaba - Market implied CFROI



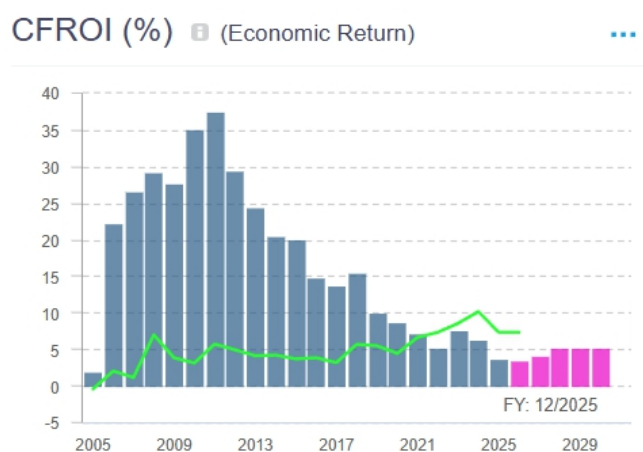
Source: UBS HOLT.

Figure 18: Alibaba - Market implied Asset Growth



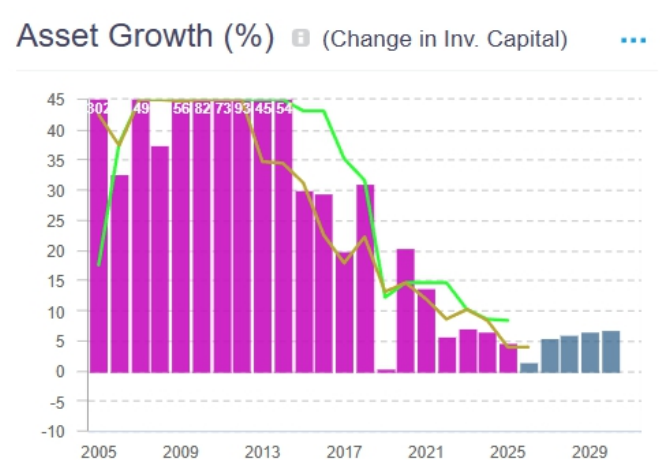
Source: UBS HOLT.

Figure 19: Baidu - Market implied CFROI



Source: UBS HOLT.

Figure 20: Baidu - Market implied Asset Growth



Source: UBS HOLT.

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Additional Prices: Alibaba Group, US\$118.90 (28 Aug 2026); Baidu, Inc., US\$97.12 (28 Aug 2026); Tencent Holdings, HK\$455.20 (28 Aug 2026); Baidu, HK\$95.75 (28 Aug 2026); Alibaba Group, HK\$113.90 (28 Aug 2026); Source: UBS. All prices as of local market close.

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